

Bangkok Travel Guide

Quick Facts

- **Country:** Thailand
- **Language:** Thai (English widely spoken in tourist areas)
- **Currency:** Thai Baht (THB, ฿)
- **Time Zone:** Indochina Time (ICT, UTC+7, no daylight saving)
- **Emergency Number:** 191 (tourist police), 1669 (ambulance)
- **Dialing Code:** +66
- **Capital:** Bangkok is the capital of Thailand
- **Population:** ~10.5 million (metropolitan area ~16 million)

Visa Requirements

Entry Rules by Nationality

Thailand offers visa-exempt entry for many nationalities:

- **US Citizens:** Visa-free for tourism up to **60 days** (extended from 30 days in 2024)
- **UK Citizens:** Visa-free for tourism up to **60 days**
- **Canadian Citizens:** Visa-free for tourism up to **60 days**
- **Australian Citizens:** Visa-free for tourism up to **60 days**
- **EU Citizens:** Visa-free for tourism up to **60 days**
- **Other Nationals:** Many countries eligible for visa-on-arrival (15-30 days) at airports
- **Check Latest:** Visit [Thai Ministry of Foreign Affairs](#) for current requirements

Important Requirements

- **Passport Validity:** Must be valid for at least **6 months** from date of entry
- **Return Ticket:** Immigration may ask to see proof of onward travel
- **Accommodation Proof:** May request hotel booking confirmation
- **Cash:** May ask to show 20,000 THB per person (rarely enforced but carry some cash)
- **Extensions:** Can extend stay by 30 days at immigration office (1,900 THB fee)

Visa Types for Longer Stays

- **Tourist Visa:** 60 days (extendable), apply at Thai embassy before travel
- **Special Tourist Visa (STV):** 90 days (can extend to 270 days)
- **Education Visa:** For studying Thai language or other courses
- **Work Permit:** Required for employment (employer sponsors)

Best Time to Visit

Cool and Dry Season (November - February)

- **Weather:** Pleasant (20-32°C / 68-90°F), low humidity, minimal rain
- **Pros:** Best weather, festivals (Loy Krathong in November), comfortable for sightseeing
- **Cons:** Peak tourist season, higher prices, crowded attractions
- **Best for:** First-time visitors, temple sightseeing, rooftop bars

Hot Season (March - May)

- **Weather:** Very hot (28-40°C / 82-104°F), dry, intense sun
- **Pros:** Fewer tourists, lower prices, Songkran water festival (mid-April)
- **Cons:** Oppressive heat (especially April), exhausting for outdoor activities
- **Best for:** Budget travelers, Songkran festival experience, indoor attractions

Rainy Season / Monsoon (June - October)

- **Weather:** Hot and humid (25-35°C / 77-95°F), frequent afternoon/evening showers
- **Pros:** Lowest prices, lush greenery, short bursts of rain (not all day), manageable with planning
- **Cons:** Occasional flooding, humidity, less ideal for outdoor activities
- **Best for:** Budget travelers, shopping, food tours (covered markets)

Peak Season: November-February (book accommodation early) **Shoulder Season:** March, October **Low Season:** June-September

Pro Tip: Even during rainy season, mornings are often clear. Plan outdoor activities early, shopping/museums for afternoon.

Top Attractions

Attraction	District	Entry Fee	Hours	Best Time to Visit	Must-See Feature
Grand Palace	Rattanakosin	500 THB	8:30-15:30 (last entry)	Opening time (least crowded)	Temple of the Emerald Buddha
Wat Pho (Reclining Buddha)	Rattanakosin	300 THB	8:00-18:30	Morning before 10am	46-meter gold reclining Buddha
Wat Arun (Temple of Dawn)	Thonburi	100 THB	8:00-18:00	Sunset or early morning	Climb the prang for river views
Chatuchak Weekend Market	Chatuchak	Free	Sat-Sun 9:00-18:00	Morning (cooler, less crowded)	15,000 stalls, everything imaginable
Khao San Road	Rattanakosin	Free	24/7 (lively evening)	Evening/night	Backpacker hub, street food, nightlife
Chinatown (Yaowarat)	Chinatown	Free	Evening best	Sunset-midnight	Street food heaven, gold shops
Jim Thompson House	Siam	200 THB	9:00-18:00	Morning	Traditional Thai houses, silk history
Floating Markets	Various	10-100 THB	Early morning (6-11am)	Dawn	Damnoen Saduak (touristy) or Amphawa (authentic)
Sky Bar at Lebua	Silom	Free (drinks ~800 THB)	18:00-01:00	Sunset	Rooftop bar from "The Hangover 2"
Lumpini Park	Silom	Free	4:30-21:00	Early morning or late afternoon	Monitor lizards, jogging, tai chi
Asiatique Riverfront	Charoen Krung	Free	16:00-24:00	Evening	Night market, Ferris wheel, riverside dining
MBK Center	Siam	Free	10:00-22:00	Afternoon (A/C escape)	8-floor shopping mall, bargains

Insider Tips

- **Dress Code:** Temples require covered shoulders and knees (pants/long skirts). Bring a sarong or rent at entrance (20-50 THB).
- **Temple Hopping:** Grand Palace → Wat Pho (5-min walk) → Wat Arun (ferry across river, 5 THB) makes efficient morning route.
- **Avoid Scams:** Near Grand Palace, tuk-tuk drivers will say it's "closed today" and offer tour - ignore and enter anyway.
- **Free Ferries:** Cross river on local ferries (3-5 THB) instead of tourist boats (50+ THB).

Neighborhoods & Districts

Rattanakosin (Old City)

- **Character:** Historic heart, royal palaces, temples, Bangkok's original settlement
- **Must-See:** Grand Palace, Wat Pho, Khao San Road, National Museum
- **Food:** Cheap street food, backpacker cafes, traditional Thai restaurants
- **Transport:** No metro (BTS/MRT), use taxis/tuk-tuks/boats, very walkable
- **Stay Here If:** First-time visitor wanting temples and history

Sukhumvit

- **Character:** Modern, cosmopolitan, expat hub, malls, international restaurants
- **Must-See:** Terminal 21 mall, Benjakitti Park, nightlife (Soi 11, Soi Cowboy)
- **Food:** Every cuisine imaginable, fine dining, rooftop bars, street food
- **Transport:** BTS Skytrain (Nana, Asok, Phrom Phong stations), very convenient
- **Stay Here If:** You want modern Bangkok with excellent transport

Silom

- **Character:** Financial district by day, nightlife hub after hours, LGBTQ+ friendly
- **Must-See:** Lumpini Park, rooftop bars (Sky Bar, Octave), Patpong night market
- **Food:** Business lunch deals, rooftop dining, street food on Convent Road
- **Transport:** BTS (Sala Daeng), MRT (Silom, Lumpini)
- **Stay Here If:** You want central location with nightlife and business amenities

Khao San Road Area

- **Character:** Legendary backpacker street, budget travel hub, 24/7 party zone
- **Must-See:** The street itself (experience!), nearby temples, Phra Athit Road (quieter)
- **Food:** Cheap Thai, Western backpacker food, street stalls, pad thai at midnight
- **Transport:** No BTS/MRT nearby (deliberate choice by area!), taxis/tuk-tuks, river boats
- **Stay Here If:** Budget traveler, want backpacker social scene, close to temples

Thonburi (West Bank)

- **Character:** Quieter, more local, residential, fewer tourists, traditional Bangkok
- **Must-See:** Wat Arun, canal tours (khlongs), Artist's House, local markets
- **Food:** Authentic Thai food, family restaurants, less touristy
- **Transport:** Ferry across river, MRT Blue Line extension, buses
- **Stay Here If:** You want authentic local experience away from tourist crowds

Chinatown (Yaowarat)

- **Character:** Chaotic, colorful, bustling, gold shops, incredible street food
- **Must-See:** Yaowarat Road at night, Sampeng Market, Wat Traimit (Golden Buddha)
- **Food:** Best street food in Bangkok, Chinese-Thai fusion, seafood, dim sum
- **Transport:** MRT (Wat Mangkon, Hua Lamphong), walk from Rattanakosin
- **Visit For:** Food tour (must!), market shopping, cultural immersion

Food & Dining

Must-Try Thai Dishes

- **Pad Thai:** Stir-fried rice noodles with tamarind sauce, egg, peanuts, lime
- **Tom Yum Goong:** Hot and sour soup with prawns, lemongrass, galangal
- **Som Tam:** Spicy green papaya salad (tell them "mai pet" for less spicy!)
- **Massaman Curry:** Rich, mild curry with peanuts, potatoes, beef or chicken
- **Khao Pad:** Thai fried rice with egg, vegetables, meat
- **Mango Sticky Rice:** Sweet coconut rice with ripe mango (dessert heaven)
- **Satay:** Grilled meat skewers with peanut sauce
- **Pad Krapow Moo Saap:** Holy basil stir-fry with pork and fried egg

- **Boat Noodles:** Small bowls of rich, flavorful noodle soup

Where to Eat

Street Food (Must Experience!)

- **Price:** 40-100 THB per dish
- **Where:** Yaowarat (Chinatown), Khao San Road, Sukhumvit Soi 38, Ari neighborhood
- **Safety:** Choose stalls with high turnover (fresh ingredients), cooked-to-order
- **Best:** Don't fear the street stalls - often better and more authentic than restaurants

Food Courts

- **Price:** 50-150 THB per meal
- **Where:** MBK Center, Terminal 21, Siam Paragon
- **How:** Buy prepaid card, order from stalls, refund unused credit
- **Benefit:** A/C, clean, variety, cheap, tourist-friendly

Restaurants

- **Budget:** 100-200 THB (local restaurants, no A/C)
- **Mid-Range:** 300-600 THB (nice Thai restaurants, international food)
- **Fine Dining:** 1,500+ THB (Michelin-starred, rooftop restaurants)

Night Markets

- **Rod Fai Market:** Hipster vintage market with food stalls
- **Talad Rot Fai Srinakarin:** Huge night market, local crowd, great food
- **Asiatique:** Touristy but scenic riverside setting

Dining Customs & Etiquette

- **Spice Levels:** Thai food can be extremely spicy! Say "mai pet" (not spicy) or "pet nit noi" (a little spicy)
- **Sharing:** Thai meals are meant to be shared - order variety and share with table
- **Fork & Spoon:** Use spoon as main utensil (right hand), fork to push food onto spoon (chopsticks for noodles)
- **Tipping:** Not traditionally expected, but appreciated. Round up or leave 20-40 THB, high-end restaurants 10%
- **Water:** Don't drink tap water. Bottled water everywhere (7-10 THB at 7-Eleven)

- **Ice:** Generally safe in restaurants/stalls with high turnover
- **Halal/Vegetarian:** Say "gin jeh" for vegetarian, "halal" widely available especially in Muslim areas

Street Food Safety Tips

- **Choose Wisely:** High customer turnover = fresh ingredients
- **Cooked to Order:** Safer than pre-cooked sitting out
- **Hot Food:** Thoroughly cooked and served hot is safest
- **Avoid:** Raw vegetables if you have a sensitive stomach (first few days)
- **Stick to:** Grilled, fried, boiled dishes

Transportation

From Suvarnabhumi Airport (BKK)

- **Airport Rail Link (ARL):** To Phaya Thai BTS station (30 min, 45 THB) or Makkasan (City Air Terminal)
- **Taxi:** Metered from official stand on level 1 (250-400 THB + 50 THB airport surcharge + tolls ~75 THB), 45-90 min depending on traffic
- **Grab:** Similar to taxi, order from arrivals level
- **Limousine Services:** More expensive but convenient (1,000+ THB)
- **Bus:** Cheap but slow (35-60 THB, 1-2 hours)

From Don Mueang Airport (DMK)

- **Bus:** A1, A2 to BTS/MRT stations (30 THB)
- **Taxi:** Metered (200-350 THB + airport surcharge + tolls)
- **Train:** Free train to Don Mueang station, then train to Hua Lamphong (slow, cheap)

BTS Skytrain

- **Coverage:** Sukhumvit Line (light green) and Silom Line (dark green)
- **Hours:** 6:00-24:00
- **Tickets:** 17-65 THB depending on distance, day pass 140 THB, Rabbit Card (stored value)
- **Best For:** Sukhumvit, Siam, Silom areas - fast, efficient, A/C

MRT (Metro)

- **Coverage:** Blue Line (loop), Purple Line (north), Yellow Line (east)
- **Hours:** 6:00-24:00
- **Tickets:** 16-42 THB, day pass 120-140 THB, stored value card
- **Best For:** Connecting BTS gaps, Chinatown, Chatuchak Market

Taxis & Ride-Sharing

- **Metered Taxis:** Abundant, starting fare 35 THB, ~7 THB per km
- **Always Use Meter:** Say "meter, please" or "by meter" - refuse fixed price offers
- **Grab:** Ride-hailing app, shows price upfront, convenient, widely used
- **Bolt:** Similar to Grab, competitive pricing
- **Traffic:** Avoid rush hours (7-9am, 5-8pm) - can double journey time

Tuk-Tuks

- **Iconic:** Three-wheeled motorized rickshaw, quintessential Bangkok experience
- **Always Negotiate:** No meter, agree price before getting in
- **Price Guide:** Short trip 50-100 THB, longer 100-200 THB (usually more expensive than taxi!)
- **When:** Fun for short trips, tourist experience, not practical for daily transport
- **Scams:** Drivers offer "20 THB tours" then take you to gem shops for commission - politely decline

Boats & Ferries

- **Chao Phraya Express Boat:** River ferry (10-40 THB), tourist boat (60 THB all-day pass)
- **Khlong Boats:** Canal boats (9-19 THB), cheap and scenic but chaotic for first-timers
- **Cross-River Ferries:** 3-5 THB, connect both banks
- **Best For:** Avoiding traffic, scenic travel, reaching riverside attractions

Motorcycle Taxis

- **Orange Vests:** Drivers wear numbered orange vests at designated stands
- **Short Trips:** Navigate through traffic, soi (alley) shortcuts
- **Price:** 10-40 THB for very short distances
- **Safety:** No helmets often, use at your own risk, not for tourists with large bags

Traffic Warning

- **Rush Hour:** 7-9am, 5-8pm - absolutely avoid taxis during these times
- **Alternative:** Use BTS/MRT during rush hour, much faster
- **Friday Evening:** Worst traffic of the week

Cultural Tips & Customs

Respect for the Monarchy

- **Lèse-majesté Laws:** Insulting the monarchy is illegal (3-15 years imprisonment)
- **Show Respect:** Stand for royal anthem in cinemas/theaters, don't criticize monarchy
- **Currency:** Never step on coins/bills (they have King's image)
- **Serious:** This is not taken lightly - tourists have been arrested

Buddhist Customs

- **Temples:** Remove shoes before entering, dress modestly (shoulders and knees covered)
- **Buddha Images:** Never climb on, point feet at, or touch disrespectfully
- **Monks:** Women cannot touch monks or hand things directly (place on table)
- **Photos:** Ask before photographing monks or during ceremonies

The Wai Greeting

- **What:** Press palms together at chest, slight bow
- **When:** Greet elders, show respect, thank someone
- **Don't Overdo:** Not expected with service staff receiving payment, vendors, or equals
- **Return It:** If someone wais you, wai back (except children)

Head and Feet

- **Head is Sacred:** Don't touch anyone's head (including children)
- **Feet are Lowest:** Don't point feet at people, Buddha images, or monks
- **Sitting:** Tuck feet under when sitting on floor in temples
- **Stepping Over:** Walk around people, not over them

Dress & Appearance

- **Temples:** Shoulders and knees covered mandatory (sarongs available at entrance)
- **Grand Palace:** Strictly enforced - no shorts, sleeveless tops, torn jeans
- **General:** Dress neatly; Thais judge by appearance (shabby dress = less respect)
- **Beach Wear:** For beaches only, not for walking around city
- **Shoes:** Remove before entering homes, some shops, temples

Social Etiquette

- **Mai Pen Rai:** "Never mind" / "no worries" - Thai attitude of letting go
- **Sanuk:** Fun is important - Thais prioritize enjoyment and smile
- **Sabai Sabai:** Take it easy, don't stress
- **Kreng Jai:** Consideration for others' feelings, avoid confrontation
- **Losing Face:** Raising voice or showing anger = losing face (highly negative)
- **Smile:** "Land of Smiles" for a reason - smile often, especially when asking for help

Do's and Don'ts

DO: - Remove shoes before entering temples and homes - Dress modestly at temples - Show respect for Buddha images and monks - Smile and stay calm in all situations - Learn basic Thai phrases ("sawatdee krap/ka", "kop khun krap/ka")

DON'T: - Touch anyone's head - Point feet at people or Buddha images - Step over people or food - Raise your voice or show anger - Wear shoes inside temples/homes - Criticize the monarchy (seriously!)

Language Tips

- **Sawatdee krap/ka:** Hello (men say "krap", women say "ka")
- **Kop khun krap/ka:** Thank you
- **Mai pen rai:** No problem / You're welcome
- **Chai:** Yes
- **Mai:** No
- **Aroi:** Delicious
- **Tao rai?:** How much?
- **Bin, please:** Bill, please (in restaurants)
- **Mai pet:** Not spicy

- **Phet nit noi:** A little spicy

Safety & Health

Safety Overview

Bangkok is generally safe for tourists, but petty crime (pickpocketing, scams) exists in tourist areas.

Safe City But Stay Alert

- **Violent Crime:** Rare against tourists
- **Petty Crime:** Pickpocketing in crowded areas (markets, BTS during rush hour)
- **Bag Snatching:** Occasional, especially on motorcycles - wear crossbody bags
- **Late Night:** Generally safe, but use common sense (avoid dark alleys alone)

Common Scams

- **Gem Scam:** Friendly stranger suggests "duty-free gem store" or "special deal today" - massive scam, avoid
- **Tuk-Tuk Tours:** "20 THB tour" ends at tailors/gem shops where driver gets commission
- **Grand Palace Closed:** Scammers say palace is closed, offer alternative tour - ignore and enter
- **Jet Ski Scam:** At Pattaya beaches, operators claim damage and demand huge payment
- **Taxi Not Using Meter:** Always insist on meter, walk away if they refuse
- **Overcharging:** Count change, verify prices (especially in touristy areas)
- **Friendly Local:** Overly helpful strangers may lead to scam - polite but cautious

Transportation Safety

- **Official Taxis:** Use metered taxis from stands or Grab app
- **Motorcycle Taxis:** Risky (no helmets often), avoid if risk-averse
- **Crossing Streets:** Traffic doesn't always stop - cross at lights, use pedestrian bridges
- **Tuk-Tuks:** Hang on tight, no seatbelts, thrilling but not safest

Health & Medical

- **Hospitals:** Excellent private hospitals (Bumrungrad, Bangkok Hospital) - expensive but high quality
- **Insurance:** Essential - medical tourism common, costs can be high

- **Pharmacies:** 7-Eleven, Boots, Watson's everywhere - many medications available over-counter
- **Travel Vaccines:** Consult doctor - Hepatitis A, Typhoid, Tetanus recommended
- **Dengue:** Mosquito-borne disease, use repellent (especially rainy season)
- **Air Quality:** Can be poor, check AQI if sensitive

Food & Water

- **Tap Water:** Not drinkable - bottled water everywhere (cheap)
- **Ice:** Generally safe in restaurants/stalls with high turnover
- **Street Food:** Safe if cooked fresh with high turnover
- **Traveler's Tummy:** Common first few days - bring Imodium, stay hydrated
- **Spicy Food:** Can upset stomach - start mild, increase gradually

Heat & Sun

- **Hot Year-Round:** Stay hydrated, drink 3+ liters water daily
- **Heat Exhaustion:** Real risk - seek A/C, drink electrolytes, rest in heat of day
- **Sunscreen:** Essential, high SPF, reapply often
- **A/C Escape:** Malls, BTS/MRT are A/C sanctuaries

Emergency Numbers

- **Tourist Police:** 1155 (English spoken)
- **General Police:** 191
- **Ambulance:** 1669
- **Fire:** 199
- **Embassy:** Keep your country's contact info

Practical Information

Electricity

- **Voltage:** 220V, 50Hz
- **Plug Types:** Type A (2-pin flat), Type B (2-pin flat + ground), Type C (2-pin round)
- **Adapters:** Often not needed for US/EU plugs (most sockets accept both)
- **Where to Buy:** 7-Eleven, airports, electronics malls (Pantip Plaza)

Money & Banking

- **Currency:** Thai Baht (THB, ฿)
- **ATMs:** Everywhere, withdraw 20,000-30,000 THB max per transaction
- **ATM Fees:** 220 THB per withdrawal + your bank's fee (expensive!)
- **Exchange:** Super Rich (orange or green branches), better rates than banks
- **Credit Cards:** Accepted at malls, hotels, upscale restaurants; not at street food
- **Cash King:** Most places prefer cash, carry 500-1,000 THB daily
- **Daily Budget:** Budget 1,000-1,500 THB, mid-range 2,500-4,000 THB, luxury 6,000+ THB

7-Eleven Ubiquity

- **Everywhere:** Literally every corner, open 24/7
- **Services:** ATM, snacks, drinks, toiletries, SIM cards, bill payment
- **Reliable:** Clean bathrooms (some locations), A/C, consistent prices
- **Pro Tip:** Your go-to for water, snacks, and emergency supplies

Pharmacies

- **Chains:** Boots, Watson's, Fascino in malls
- **7-Eleven:** Basic medications
- **Over-Counter:** Many prescription drugs available without prescription
- **Cost:** Cheap compared to Western countries

SIM Cards & Internet

- **Providers:** AIS, TrueMove, DTAC
- **Tourist SIM:** 200-500 THB for 7-30 days with data
- **Where to Buy:** Airport (convenient but pricier), 7-Eleven, provider shops
- **Data:** 10-20 GB typical for tourist SIM, unlimited social media
- **WiFi:** Free in malls, cafes, hotels (ask for password)

Tap Water

- **Don't Drink:** Not safe for foreigners
- **Brushing Teeth:** Generally okay, some use bottled to be safe
- **Showering:** Completely safe
- **Bottles:** 7-10 THB at 7-Eleven for 600ml

Business Hours

- **Shops:** 10:00-20:00 or 21:00 (malls open until 22:00)
- **Street Food:** Early morning to late night (varies by location)
- **Temples:** Usually 8:00-17:00 or 18:00
- **7-Eleven:** 24/7 (some smaller ones close midnight)

Useful Apps

- **Grab/Bolt:** Ride-hailing (essential)
- **Google Maps:** Navigation, works well in Bangkok
- **Google Translate:** Camera translate for Thai script
- **XE Currency:** Exchange rates
- **Hungry Hub:** Restaurant reservations with discounts
- **BKK Delivery Apps:** GrabFood, FoodPanda, LINE MAN

Public Toilets

- **Malls:** Free, clean, Western-style
- **BTS/MRT:** Some stations have toilets (5 THB)
- **7-Eleven:** Some have toilets (hit or miss)
- **Temples:** Often available (donation appreciated)
- **Toilet Paper:** Carry tissues (not always provided, bin not flush)
- **Squat Toilets:** Common outside tourist areas

Shopping

- **Malls:** Siam Paragon, CentralWorld, MBK, Terminal 21, Emporium
- **Markets:** Chatuchak (weekend), Rod Fai (night), Sampeng (Chinatown wholesale)
- **Bargaining:** Expected at markets (not malls), start at 50% of asking price
- **VAT Refund:** Spend 2,000+ THB at VAT Refund shops, claim at airport (7% refund)

Festivals

- **Songkran (mid-April):** Water festival / Thai New Year - massive water fight, banks/offices closed 3-5 days
 - **Loy Krathong (November):** Floating lanterns and baskets on water, beautiful
 - **Chinese New Year (Jan/Feb):** Chinatown celebrations
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Travel Responsibly: Be respectful of Thai culture, especially regarding monarchy and Buddhism. Support local businesses, avoid elephant riding (unethical tourism), and dress modestly at temples.

Pro Tip: Bangkok rewards those who explore beyond the main sights. Wander the sois (alleys) in Sukhumvit, take a khlong boat tour, eat where there's no English menu, and chat with locals. The real Bangkok reveals itself when you venture off the beaten path.